

TROPHY

Meller Breaks the Record Book, Then Holds On

Henry Meller opened with -13 and -15 — the two lowest rounds TEG had recorded — and had just enough of that cushion left after two flat days to take the TEG 7 Trophy by 7.

Henry Meller settled the TEG 7 Trophy inside two days, which is an ungracious way to treat a four-round tournament and entirely permitted. His opening -13 at Praia D'El Rey was the best round in TEG history to that point, built on a closing run of ten shots to par across holes 10 to 18, where he played the last nine in three over gross for a personal-best gross round of +12.

The following day at Bom Sucesso he beat his own new mark, going round in -15 — again the best in TEG history — with nine shots to par picked up between the 3rd and the 9th. His +10 gross there was the second-best gross round recorded in TEG to date. A man who breaks the all-time record and then finds it standing in his way the next morning is not really competing with the field any more.

That was effectively the tournament. Meller's lead reached 20 shots at its widest, and the last two rounds were a matter of managing the leak rather than adding to it. The final day back at Praia D'El Rey included a quadruple-bogey eight at the 9th. He had by then accumulated so vast a surplus that the hole could be given away without comment, like small change to a busker. It was an act of grand, unhurried generosity towards men who could not possibly benefit from it. Both Gregg Williams and Stuart Neumann did make ground late — Williams from 20 back, Neumann from 17 — and each finished seven adrift.

Meller took the Trophy at -31, the lowest winning total of his career and the second-lowest in TEG history. His gross total of +69 was also a personal best. David Mullin, meanwhile, led the TEG 7 Green Jacket after the final round.

AT A GLANCE
Trophy Winner Henry Meller (1st Trophy) Runner-up: Gregg Williams
Green Jacket David Mullin (5th Jacket) Runner-up: Stuart Neumann
Wooden Spoon Alex Baker (1st Spoon) Next above: Jon Baker

FINAL · TROPHY
HM -31 | GW -24 | SN -24 | DM -23 | JB -13 | AB -5

FINAL · GREEN JACKET
DM +53 | SN +68 | HM +69 | JB +71 | GW +104 | AB +139

GREEN JACKET

Mullin Rewrites the Gross Record and Strolls

David Mullin beat Stuart Neumann on all four days and won the TEG 7 Green Jacket by 15, his +9 at Bom Sucesso the lowest gross round TEG had seen.

David Mullin won the TEG 7 Green Jacket at +53, fifteen shots clear of Stuart Neumann, and the total stands as the second-best gross aggregate in TEG history as well as the second-best of Mullin's own career.

The decisive round came on the Friday at Bom Sucesso, where his 81 — +9 to par — became the lowest gross round yet recorded in a TEG. The same card was worth -10 against net par, a personal best for Mullin on that measure.

Neumann's +10 the same day was itself the second-best gross round in the record book, and it still lost ground. There is no crueller way to play well.

Royal Óbidos was the exception, the auditor having found Mullin's file too. He went round in 90, including a quintuple-bogey eight at the par-three 15th, the worst he has made on a par three, and his two nines differed by eleven shots. Even so, Neumann took 99 on the same course.

The last day at Praia D'El Rey brought his 83, +10 gross and the second-best gross round in TEG history. It was not tidy: five straight pars from the 4th, then a bogey at the 9th and a triple bogey at the 10th, answered immediately by a birdie at the short 11th, as though nothing had happened and nobody had seen. Two more pars followed before a double bogey at the 14th. Neumann finished on +68, a career-best gross total, and 15 adrift.

SIDEBAR

The Record Book Lasted One Day

Henry Meller's -13 at Praia D'El Rey was the lowest round TEG had recorded — until Bom Sucesso, where he and two rivals produced the best scoring in the tournament's history.

TEG 7 on the Lisbon Coast began with Praia D'El Rey being taken apart. Henry Meller opened with a net 13 under par, the best round in TEG history to date, built on a gross +12 that was his own personal best. In the same round Jon Baker went round in +11 gross — a TEG record of its own — for a net -10, the third-best round recorded to that point.

All of it lasted a day. At Bom Sucesso on the Friday, Meller went to -15 and broke his own two-day-old mark. Stuart Neumann's -13 was the second-best round in TEG history, and David Mullin's +9 gross took the gross record off Baker inside 24 hours. Mullin's net -10 was a personal best. Both Neumann and Meller signed for +10 gross, the joint second-best gross rounds on record. The record book, at this point, was less a document than a wall being repeatedly repainted.

Then came Saturday and Seve Ballesteros' Royal Óbidos, which declined to co-operate. It arrived in the manner of an auditor: unhurried, uninterested in the previous two days, and holding a list. Mullin, who had shot 81 at Bom Sucesso, needed 90 here; Meller took 96, Baker 98, Neumann 99. The damage was concentrated. Mullin ran up an eight at the par-three 15th, a quintuple bogey and his worst score on any par three. Neumann took nine at the 12th, a par four and the second-hardest hole on the card — another quintuple bogey. Two days of records, one day of correction.

SIDEBAR

Williams Finishes Fastest, Seven Too Late

Gregg Williams, twice the reigning Trophy champion, was 20 adrift at one stage and answered with the best round of his TEG career on the final day at Praia D'El Rey.

Gregg Williams spent three days making the TEG 7 Trophy an impossibility, and did so with considerable application. At Bom Sucesso on the Friday he ran up a nine at the 15th, a par four and stroke index two, for a quintuple bogey. Royal Óbidos was worse: an eight at the 4th on Saturday morning, then another nine at the 14th. That round did at least show a pulse late — his back nine was ten shots better than his front, and he signed for 100 gross, four under his handicap allowance in net terms.

At his lowest point he trailed the Trophy lead by 20 shots. Sunday's return to Praia D'El Rey produced the best round of his TEG career on both counts: 20 over gross, 12 under par net, a personal best on each measure and a 93 that stands as his best gross of the tournament. The scoring was not spectacular so much as relentless — a par at the 3rd followed by four straight bogeys through the 7th, each of them a shot gained against his allowance, five in the space of five holes. Bogey golf as a form of quiet accumulation.

It closed 13 shots of the gap and left him seven off the Trophy lead at the finish, which is to say it arrived a day or two late and with nothing riding on it. The round still counts as the best he has played.

JON BAKER

From the Best Round Ever to an Eleven

Jon Baker's opening +11 gross was the finest round in TEG history; by the closing round at the same course he had a sextuple-bogey 11 on his card and fifth place in the TEG 7 Trophy.

Jon Baker opened TEG 7 with the best gross round in TEG history to date. His 84 at Praia D'El Rey came in at +11 gross, and in net terms it was worth -10, the third-best round recorded in TEG history at that point. It left him second in the TEG 7 Trophy and first in the TEG 7 Green Jacket after one day.

It did not hold. By the third round at Royal Óbidos the damage was arriving in single lumps rather than by instalment: a 10 at the par-five 2nd, then a 7 at the par-three 3rd, back-to-back, on the way to a 98 — his highest round of the four days.

The final round at Praia D'El Rey offered a brief recovery. Baker played holes 2 to 5 in four straight pars without dropping a gross shot, gaining five shots on his net target across the stretch. Order was restored. Then came the 10th, a par five, where he signed for 11 — a sextuple bogey, and the worst hole relative to par of his career. The par-three 11th followed with a 7, in case anyone had mistaken the 10th for a misunderstanding.

He finished fifth in the Trophy and fourth in the Green Jacket, three places down in each from where round one had put him.

WOODEN SPOON | ALEX BAKER

The Steadiest Man in Portugal Finishes Last

Alex Baker took the bottom of the TEG 7 Wooden Spoon race in the opening round and never got off it, ending 8 adrift of his brother Jon Baker.

Alex Baker's TEG 7 Wooden Spoon was decided almost as soon as the tournament began. He reached the foot of the Spoon standings on the 14th hole of the opening round at Praia D'El Rey, and across the remaining three and a half rounds on the Lisbon Coast he never climbed back out of it. Others rose, others fell. Baker remained, immovable, like a bollard.

The final margin was recorded at -5 net versus par, the measure by which the Spoon is settled, and Baker duly collected it.

None of the three courses in the 2014 rotation had been played by the group before, so there was no local knowledge to fall back on and nothing to measure the four days against. Baker's best gross of the tournament came in the second round at Bom Sucesso, a 102 on Donald Steel's parkland layout at Caldas da Rainha. He followed that with 108 at Seve Ballesteros's Royal Óbidos in round three, and his better visit to Praia D'El Rey produced a 109 on the closing Sunday, an improvement on the round in which his tournament had effectively been settled. Three courses, none of them previously seen, all of them in agreement.

The position he took on Thursday afternoon was the position he held on Sunday evening.

RECORDS & PERSONAL BESTS

Notable achievements: TEG 7

TEG RECORDS

- David Mullin's +10 (gross) is the 2nd-best Gross round in TEG history to date (R4)
- David Mullin's +9 (gross) is the best Gross round in TEG history to date (R2)
- Henry Meller's -15 is the best round in TEG history to date (R2)
- Stuart Neumann's -13 is the 2nd-best round in TEG history to date (R2)
- Stuart Neumann's +10 (gross) is the 2nd-best Gross round in TEG history to date (R2)
- Henry Meller's +10 (gross) is the 2nd-best Gross round in TEG history to date (R2)
- Jon Baker's +11 (gross) is the best Gross round in TEG history to date (R1)
- Henry Meller's -13 is the best round in TEG history to date (R1)
- Jon Baker's -10 is the 3rd-best round in TEG history to date (R1)

PERSONAL BESTS

- Gregg Williams posts a personal-best round: -12 (R4)
- Gregg Williams posts a personal-best Gross round: +20 (R4)
- David Mullin posts a personal-best round: -10 (R2)
- Henry Meller posts a personal-best Gross round: +12 (R1)
- Henry Meller's +69 is a personal Gross best
- Stuart Neumann's +68 is a personal Gross best
- David Mullin's -23 is a personal Trophy best
- Henry Meller's -31 is a personal Trophy best
- Stuart Neumann's -24 is a personal Trophy best
- Henry Meller — +2 Gross on the Back nine (R1) is a personal-best Back nine Gross
- Henry Meller — -10 net-vs-par on the Back nine (R1) is a personal-best Back nine net-vs-par
- Stuart Neumann — -8 net-vs-par on the Front nine (R2) is a personal-best Front nine net-vs-par
- David Mullin's 5-hole "Pars or Better" streak is a personal best (previous 4), at T07 R4 H4 to T07 R4 H8

RARE FEATS

- Jon Baker runs up an 11 (+6) at the 10th (R4) — his career-worst on a par-5
- David Mullin runs up an 8 (+5) at the 15th (R3) — his career-worst on a par-3
- Alex Baker runs up an 8 (+5) at the 5th (R1) — his career-worst on a par-3